across Karnataka, while Chief Minister Veerappa Moily accused the BJP of being responsible for the deaths.[58]

Why did the flag-hoisting become such a contentious issue? For the Congress government, as officials briefed reporters at the time, the BJP's call for a huge crowd to gather 'clearly indicates that the intention is to provoke people and create a violent atmosphere not just in Hubli but in the entire state'. To the AeI, the flag-hoisting seemed like a threatened land grab and they feared that a crowd could bring down the disputed structure.[59] Former Hubli mayor Firdous Kunoon told the journalist Veeraraghav, 'Muslims were scared that if you want to put a pole and hoist a flag, you will prove it's your property or public property.' The BJP projected it as the litmus test of patriotism. As Firdous put it, 'In my schooldays, in the same ground, there were firecracker shows at night on the last day of Ganesh pooja, but that has now stopped.'[60]

As the dispute festered and communal tensions mounted, the BJP's critics accused it of playing 'divisive politics'. A newspaper editorial at the time argued, 'The BJP's objective in flaunting its patriotic credentials and taking upon itself the onerous task of checking the nationalist credentials of all citizens, especially the Muslims, is in keeping with its divisive politics, intended to strengthen its electoral base. It has not been averse in this context to adopt provocative postures and play politics with the national flag … Admittedly, if the BJP's motivated campaign to depict the Muslims as unpatriotic has influenced the gullible, it is because of the reluctance of Muslims to hoist the flag themselves at the maidan. One reason for this was that until the BJP chose the site in 1992, it had occurred to no one, including the BJP, that a flag needed to be hoisted there to prove one's devotion to the motherland.'[61]

BJP's Lehar Singh points out, 'We got a big boost with the Ayodhya movement plus what happened in the Idgah Maidan in Hubli. The Yediyurappa and Ananth Kumar combination did really well for us … Ananth Kumar and Yediyurappa successfully exploited the issue and in the process brought our MLAs from four to forty in 1994. Because of this combination and jodi [couple], we could win thirteen seats in 1999 Lok Sabha poll.'[62] BJP's Jagdish Shettar, who